

LOOKING AHEAD
(from left) **1.** Arvind Singh, Secretary, Ministry of Tourism **2.** Harshwardhan Chauhan, Minister for Industries, Himachal Pradesh **3.** Arjun Ram Meghwal, Minister for Culture and Parliamentary Affairs **4.** Satpal Maharaj, Minister for Tourism, Uttarakhand **5**. Raj Chengappa, Group Editorial Director, India Today Group with the award winners

RAJWANT RAWAT

AND REVIVAL

sha, which used to be a day's trip, now has people visiting for four-five days, thanks to the Eco Retreat 'glam camp' started just a few years ago. India's tourism sector is recognising the potential of the 'local', and it is this idea that resonated among officials and industry leaders who came together at the 2023 INDIA TODAY Tourism Survey and Awards to discuss the future of the sector as it makes a grand comeback after the Covid-19 pandemic.

In 2019, India received nearly 11 million foreign tourists and 1.8 billion domestic tourists. Though the sector did suffer a setback during the pandemic, tourist numbers are almost back to pre-Covid-19 levels now. "Inbound tourism has picked up and domestic tourism has seen tremendous growth. New spots where tourism infrastructure has been built up are witnessing growth," says Arvind Singh, secretary, ministry of tourism.

Encouraged by these numbers, the government is on a mission mode to develop the sector. The G20 summits underway this year as well as the recognition of tourism as an immensely profitable industry have given momentum to the government's efforts. "Tourism is one of the main drivers of growth for the economy, it has immense potential to generate jobs—increasingly, green jobs—and to promote sustainable development,"